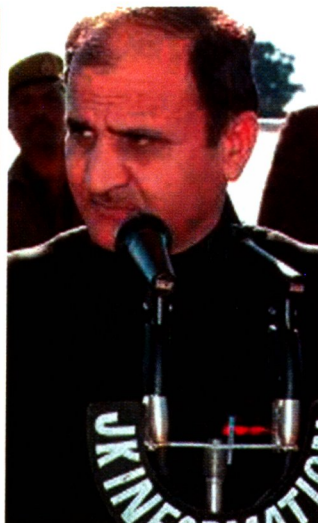


YASIN DARR



Sex and Lies in the Valley

SRINAGAR The ghost of the infamous sexploitation racket in Srinagar has returned to haunt the Congress. This time, however, the catalyst is a sitting Congress MP who has alleged that Assembly Speaker and Congress legislator Tara Chand and former state Congress president Peerzada Muhammad Sayeed were definitely involved in the sex scandal but were bailed out by Congress President Sonia Gandhi and Chief Minister Ghulam Nabi Azad.

The infamous racket had surfaced in the Habbakadal locality in Srinagar in 2006 as legislators, politicians, police and security officials were allegedly found involved in the flesh trade. The scandal had snowballed into an avalanche of violent protests as it sent out a view that the Government was using prostitution and other indecent activities as a "tool to fight the insurgency" in the state.

At a public rally in the Jammu region, Madan Lal

IN A MUDDLE: Sayeed (left) and Chand

Sharma, Congress MP from Jammu-Poonch, accused Chand and Sayeed (who recently resigned as a minister on corruption charges), of being involved in the sex racket. "They were saved by Sonia Gandhi at the behest of the chief minister to save the party from embarrassment," he said. The diatribe did not end there with Sharma demanding that Chand and Sayeed be arrested.

The charges sent shockwaves within and outside the state. Sharma has reportedly been summoned by the Congress high command to explain his conduct at a time when the party is going full throttle to consolidate its base ahead of the elections due later this year. The state Government has termed Sharma's disclosures as "utterly baseless, false and without any foundation". But coming from one of its own, the charges could not have come at a worse time for the beleaguered Congress and its chief minister.

by Aljaz Hussain

SIGNPOSTS

DEFERRED: Sarabjit Singh's hanging by the Pakistan Government for an indefinite period. He was sentenced for allegedly triggering bomb blasts in Lahore and Multan in 1990.



DIED: Nirmala Deshpande, a Gandhian two-time Rajya Sabha member, and a Padma Vibhushan

recipient. She was 79.

SENTENCED: To life imprisonment by a Delhi court, **Lt-Colonel (retd) S.J. Chaudhary** for killing Delhi businessman Krishna Sikand through a parcel bomb on October 2, 1982.

DIED: Filmmaker **Prabodh Mukherji**, 88. He produced films like the Shammi Kapoor starrer *Jungle*, *April Fool*, *Sharmili*, *Love Marriage* and *Shagird*.

AWARDED: To artist **N.S. Harsha**, the Artes Mundi prize, the highest international art prize in the UK.

VIS-A-VIS ANBUMANI RAMADOSS health minister versus SHARMILA TAGORE Film Censor Board chief

“By smoking and drinking onscreen, actors convey a wrong message to the country's young and old who watch their films.”



SAURABH SINGH

“First it was about smoking, then he spoke about chips and now alcohol. He should focus on real issues.”

EPILOGUE: Isn't the health minister aware that sensitisling is better than censoring?